

close quarters, with both my daughter and my parents getting routinely lost in social media's irresistible charms. Where a few planned minutes watching a YouTube video or Instagram Reel quickly morphs into getting sucked into the black hole of doom scrolling, lost time and



frequent regret. Here's where we need to understand that the platforms themselves are neutral tools – they're empowering for those thirsty for access to knowledge or information.

Sure, the creators of social media platforms want you to spend as much time as you can on their products, but it's ultimately how we use them that determines the impact of these platforms. Focusing on building meaningful connections can counter negativity and even enhance your life through technology.

05 Feature phones are still useful

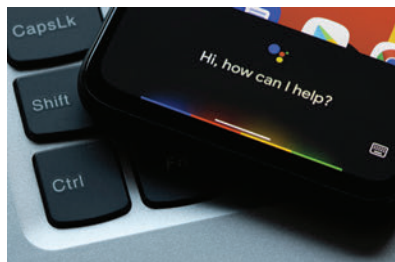
While it's true that feature phones don't offer the same variety of features or processing power as touchscreen smartphones, the fact that they refuse to die says something about their continued appeal. Far from being a poor man's or older people's mobile phone, I believe feature phones have a lot to offer for advanced users of technology.



Feature phones are generally sturdier than smartphones with huge touchscreen slabs, and they can withstand drops and harsh conditions better than most Android phones or iPhones. The simpler operating systems and restricted feature sets of these phones ensure they offer significantly longer battery life, making them ideal for situations where access to chargers is limited. Feature phones are way more cheaper than modern smartphones, making them easily accessible to people with budget constraints or those who simply don't need the high-end features. Because they're less distracting, with curtailed or no access to the internet, feature phones can be great for children and elder folk to ensure greater focus in their non-phone related activities. With all these positives, it's easy to conclude that feature phones are still useful and will continue to be in the foreseeable future.

06 Voice assistants are overrated

Voice-controlled computing is definitely exciting. I have praised it myself in the past, since it allows for



the possibility of interacting with a tiny computer or smart device without a screen, freeing us to multitask more efficiently. Voice assistants like Alexa, Siri or Google Assistant also empower people with disabilities to better access some of today's technological norms. Having said that, I do feel that the utility of voice assistants in our phones, laptops or smart devices is overrated, and that they can be routinely more frustrating than helpful due to misinterpretations and privacy concerns.

Most voice assistants have limited practical use beyond basic tasks like searching for something on the internet or setting up an alarm. Their inability to handle complex queries or nuanced instructions can be frustrating and even put people off from using them after repeated guffaws. The novelty of voice assistants can also distract from addressing more fundamental issues concerning user privacy as well. Unfortunately, voice assistants are all about overhyped promises... for now.

07 Wired connections are better than wireless

With the advent of 4G, wireless connectivity became more ubiquitous across India. According to TRAI figures for 2023, out of India's total of 881.25 million Internet subscribers, the number of wired Internet subscribers are 33.94 million and the number of wireless Internet subscribers are 847.31 million. Wireless internet took off in India not just because of cheaper cellular data rates, but also because of last mile wired connectivity across India's towns and villages.

While both wired and wireless internet have their advantages and disadvantages, wired internet often takes the lead in terms of raw performance and reliability. Wired connections offer significantly higher speeds, reaching up to gigabit levels (1 Gbps) and beyond, which allows for seamless streaming, super fast downloads, and lag-free online gaming. In comparison, Wi-Fi 6 speeds are generally lower in the 100-300 Mbps range, crossing gigabit only under ideal conditions (which is rare). Wired

